

Reading Comprehension

Chapter F8.3 — Five Marks From One Passage, and Why That Changes How You Read It

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HIGH YIELD · THE ONE FACT THAT DECIDES THE STRATEGY

Reading comprehension was **5 of the 20 English questions** in 2023 — and all five came from **ONE passage** (PYQ-DERIVED, Blueprint §4.4).

That single detail changes everything about how the format should be attacked. Reading the passage is a **fixed cost**. If it buys you one question, it is a bad trade at RT speed. If it buys you **five**, it is the best trade in the English block: one careful reading of 250 words, then **12.5 marks** on the table.

So the rule here is the opposite of the rule everywhere else in this paper. **Do not rush the passage**. Rush the options. §1.2 sets out the budget, and §2 is the reading method that makes it work.

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0. How This Chapter Works

STUDY SESSION · CHAPTER F8.3

1. **Session 1** — The format, and the five-minute budget (§1) ★★★★★
2. **Session 2** — How to read the passage once, properly (§2) ★★★★★
3. **Session 3** — The five question types, and how each is attacked (§3) ★★★★★
4. **Session 4** — The wrong-option catalogue (§4) ★★★★★
5. **Session 5** — A worked passage, option by option (§5)

Then 20 graded questions in §6 — **four passages of five questions each**, deliberately mirroring the 2023 shape rather than giving you one question per passage.

F8.0's calendar takes §6 Q1–10 on Monday of week 3 and Q11–20 on Wednesday of week 3, then re-drills in weeks 6 and 11.

NOTE · THE PASSAGES ARE REVISION AS WELL AS PRACTICE

As in F8.2, the four passages in §6 are built from material you have already studied — the contributory basis of the 1952 Act, the scope and limits of audit, ocean acidification, and platform work under the Code on Social Security.

This is deliberate. It costs nothing to make the drill do two jobs, and a passage on a subject you half know is also **the honest test** — because the exam's inference questions punish candidates who answer from prior knowledge instead of from the text. §4.3 is the trap that catches them, and you will meet it in Q12 and Q18.

1. Session 1 — The Format and the Budget ★★★★★

1.1 What the format actually is

A passage of roughly **200 to 350 words**, followed by questions. UPSC's passages in this examination are **expository or argumentative prose** — the register of a good editorial or a policy note. They are not literary, and they are not technical. Expect a claim, a qualification of the claim, and a consequence.

The 2023 paper put **five questions on one passage**. Some sittings distribute two or three passages across the same number of questions. Prepare for the concentrated version, because it is what the evidence shows and because it is the version where reading discipline pays.

1.2 The time budget

MUST MASTER · FIVE MINUTES FOR THE SET, NOT ONE MINUTE PER QUESTION

F8.0 §1.1 budgets **5 minutes for the whole passage set**. Spend it like this:

Phase	Time	What you do
Scan the stems	20 sec	Read the five question stems for their type only — not the options
Read the passage	90–110 sec	Once. Properly. Marking structure, not underlining everything
Answer	~35 sec each	In the order the questions come, except leave main-idea until last
Reserve	~30 sec	For the one question that needs a second look at the text

Why scan the stems first, and why only for type. Knowing that question 3 asks about the author's attitude makes you notice attitude while reading, which costs nothing. Reading the twenty **options** first costs 40 seconds and actively harms you: four of every five options are wrong by construction, so you are loading your memory with falsehoods before you meet the truth.

Why main-idea goes last. By the time you have answered four detail questions you have effectively re-read the passage, and the main idea has become obvious. Answering it first means answering it from an impression.

1.3 The one rule that decides most of the marks

The answer is in the passage. Not in your knowledge, not in what is generally true, not in what a sensible person would think. In the passage.

This sounds too obvious to state. It is, in practice, the single largest source of error in the format, and §4.3 explains the exact mechanism by which the examiner exploits it.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 1

1. How many questions came from how many passages in 2023?
2. What is the total time budget for the set, and how is it divided?
3. Why do you scan the stems but not the options?
4. Why is the main-idea question answered last?

2. Session 2 — Reading It Once, Properly ★★★★★

Most candidates read a passage three times: once without concentrating, once looking for the answer to question 1, and once looking for the answer to question 4. That is slower than reading it once with attention, and it produces worse answers, because a hunted-for phrase arrives without its context.

2.1 Read for the skeleton, not the flesh

An expository paragraph has a **shape**, and the shape is what the questions are about. As you read, identify four things and nothing else:

What to find	Where it usually sits	Why it matters
The claim	First or second sentence	Answers the main-idea question
The qualification	After <i>but, however, yet, although</i>	Answers the inference question
The evidence or example	The middle	Answers the explicit-detail question
The consequence	Last sentence or last paragraph	Answers the purpose question

MUST MASTER · THE TWO-LINE SUMMARY, MADE IN YOUR HEAD BEFORE YOU LOOK AT ANY OPTION

When you finish the passage, before your eyes go to the options, say to yourself in **two lines**:

What is the author claiming? What is he conceding?

If you can answer those two questions, you can answer a main-idea question, a purpose question and a tone question without going back to the text — three of the five. If you cannot, you have read the words without reading the argument, and the fastest repair is to re-read the **first and last sentences only**.

This habit is worth more than any technique in this chapter, and it takes five seconds.

2.2 The signpost words that carry the argument

The structure of an argumentative passage is signalled by a small, closed set of words. **These are the words to notice**; the nouns will still be there when you need them.

Signpost	What follows it
but, however, yet, nevertheless, on the contrary	The qualification — the most examined sentence in the passage
although, while, despite, notwithstanding	A concession the author is about to overrule
therefore, thus, hence, consequently, so	The author's own conclusion
for example, for instance, indeed, in fact	Evidence for the claim just made
moreover, furthermore, and, also	More of the same — safe to read quickly
frequently overlook, it is often assumed, popular discussion	A view the author is about to correct — see §3.5

THINK LIKE UPSC · WHY THE SENTENCE AFTER "HOWEVER" IS THE ONE TO MARK

Examiners set inference questions on the **qualification**, not on the claim, because the claim is usually uncontroversial and the qualification is where the author does something a careless reader will miss.

Read the passage in §5. Its claim — that the ocean absorbs carbon dioxide — is common knowledge. Its qualification — that seawater nonetheless **remains alkaline** — is the whole question. A candidate who skimmed will answer that the ocean has become acidic, which is precisely the option waiting for him.

Mark the sentence after "however" or "nevertheless" with a pencil tick. It is worth 2.5 marks more often than any other sentence in the passage.

3. Session 3 — The Five Question Types ★★★★★

Every RC question you will meet is one of five types. Recognising the type tells you where to look and what a right answer is allowed to look like.

Type	Stem sounds like	Where the answer is	Accept an option only if
1 Explicit detail	<i>According to the passage...</i>	In one sentence, findable	It matches that sentence, allowing for paraphrase
2 Inference	<i>It follows / the passage implies...</i>	Between two sentences	It follows necessarily, with no new fact added
3 Vocabulary in context	<i>The word X as used means...</i>	The surrounding sentence	It fits this sentence, not the dictionary generally
4 Main idea	<i>The passage is mainly about...</i>	The whole passage	It covers the whole, not one paragraph
5 Tone / purpose	<i>The author's attitude / purpose is...</i>	The verbs and adjectives	The passage's own temperature supports it

3.1 Explicit detail — the free mark

The answer is written down. The only ways to lose it are to answer from memory instead of checking, and to be caught by a **paraphrase you did not recognise**. UPSC almost never repeats the passage's wording in the correct option — it repeats the passage's wording in a **wrong** option, attached to the wrong fact. See §4.4.

3.2 Inference — necessarily, not probably

MUST MASTER · THE TEST FOR AN INFERENCE OPTION

An inference is a statement that **must be true if the passage is true**. It is not what is likely, not what the author would probably agree with, and not what the topic suggests.

The test, in one question: *could the passage be entirely true and this option still be false?* If yes, it is not the answer, however reasonable it sounds.

Two shapes to distrust immediately:

- Anything containing **all, never, only, always, must, entirely, cannot** — passages qualify, options

that do not qualify are usually overreach

- Anything requiring a **cause** where the passage gives only a **sequence** or a correlation

3.3 Vocabulary in context — the sentence decides, not the dictionary

The stem says *as used in the passage*, and it means it. A word with three dictionary senses will have exactly one that fits the sentence, and the other two will be offered as options.

Blurred means smeared out of focus, and it means not clearly distinguished. In a sentence about a distinction being blurred in popular discussion, only the second is available. This type overlaps F8.1's technique of reading the **charge** of the sentence — positive or negative — before choosing.

3.4 Main idea — the scope test

A main-idea option fails in one of exactly three ways:

1. **Too narrow** — it is true, but it is one example or one paragraph, not the passage
2. **Too broad** — it is the subject area rather than the argument ("*the passage is about social security*" is not a main idea)
3. **Not in the passage at all** — the recommendation the author never made

The right option is nearly always **the claim plus the qualification** — which is exactly the two-line summary from §2.1. That is why the habit pays.

3.5 Tone and purpose — read the verbs

The author's attitude lives in the verbs and adjectives, not in the subject matter. *Frequently overlook, fails to grasp, is often assumed* signal an author who is **correcting** a view. *Might, appears, arguably* signal caution. Outright praise or condemnation is rare in this register.

TRAP · THE TONE OPTIONS THAT ARE ALMOST NEVER RIGHT

Examiners offer emotionally strong tone words because candidates enjoy choosing them. In expository prose of this kind the answer is almost never **sarcastic, indignant, contemptuous, euphoric, despairing** or **indifferent**.

It is almost always one of: **analytical, explanatory, critical but measured, cautious, corrective**.

When two tone options survive, prefer the **milder** one. The register of a policy note does not shout.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSIONS 2 AND 3

1. What four things do you look for while reading?
2. State the two-line summary you make before looking at any option
3. Which sentence in an argumentative passage is most often the subject of the inference question?
4. Give the one-question test for an inference option
5. Name the three ways a main-idea option fails
6. Which tone words are almost never the answer?

4. Session 4 — The Wrong-Option Catalogue ★★★★★

Wrong options in this format are **manufactured**, and there are only about six patterns. Learning to name them converts comprehension into recognition, which is far faster.

#	Pattern	How it is built	How to spot it
1	The overreach	A true statement pushed to an absolute	<i>all, never, only, must, entirely</i>
2	The half-truth	First clause right, second clause wrong	Read the whole option, including the last four words
3	The outside truth	True in the world, absent from the passage	Ask <i>which sentence?</i> — if you cannot point, reject
4	The lifted phrase	The passage's exact words, attached to the wrong fact	Familiar wording feels right; check the claim, not the vocabulary
5	The reversal	Cause and effect swapped, or a comparison inverted	Re-read the direction of the relationship
6	The right answer to the wrong question	A true, well-stated point that answers a different stem	Re-read the stem after choosing

4.1 Pattern 1, the overreach — the commonest of all

The passage says extending coverage requires "*either a redefinition of employment or a shift towards the assistance model*". The option says coverage **can only** be extended by abandoning the contributory model. The passage offered two routes; the option permits one. Rejected.

4.2 Pattern 2, the half-truth — and the six-word habit

MUST MASTER · READ THE LAST SIX WORDS OF EVERY OPTION

An option that opens correctly and ends wrongly is the hardest wrong answer to catch, because you recognise the opening and stop reading.

"Audit evidence is persuasive rather than conclusive, and the auditor therefore certifies the accounts as accurate." The first half is quoted from the passage. The second half contradicts it — the whole point is that he **does not** certify.

This is the same habit Blueprint §8 prescribes for the "*which one is not correct*" format that made up about **20% of the 2023 paper**, and F8.0 §5 predicts it will be your commonest logged error. **Read the last six words of every option before you fill any bubble.**

4.3 Pattern 3, the outside truth — the trap for the well-prepared

This is the pattern that specifically punishes candidates who have studied the subject, and it is why this chapter's passages are drawn from material you know.

You know from F6.7 that an audit has a statutory scope. You know from Module 3 that the wage ceiling under the 1952 Act is ₹15,000. A passage may not mention either. An option stating a **true fact you brought with you** is still wrong, because the stem asked what the **passage** says.

The defence is mechanical: for every option you are tempted by, point at the sentence. Not the paragraph — the sentence. If your finger does not land, the option is out no matter how true it is.

4.4 Pattern 4, the lifted phrase

Distinctive wording from the passage is recycled into wrong options, because recognition feels like knowledge. Conversely, the **correct** option is usually a paraphrase in different words. So:

Unfamiliar phrasing is weak evidence against an option. Familiar phrasing is weak evidence for one.

Judge the **proposition**, not the vocabulary.

5. Session 5 — A Worked Passage ★★★★★

Read it once, making the two-line summary, then work the three questions with me.

The ocean has absorbed something like a quarter of the carbon dioxide released by human activity since industrialisation, and in doing so has slowed the warming of the atmosphere considerably. This service has not been free. Dissolved carbon dioxide forms carbonic acid, which dissociates and releases hydrogen ions, and the surface pH of the ocean has fallen from about 8.2 to about 8.1 over that period. The process is universally described as ocean acidification. The name is convenient but imprecise: seawater at pH 8.1 remains alkaline, and nothing in the projections suggests it will become acidic in any ordinary sense. What has happened is a measurable shift **towards** the acidic end of the scale, and because the scale is logarithmic, that apparently small change represents an increase of roughly thirty per cent in hydrogen ion concentration. Organisms that build shells of calcium carbonate are affected by that concentration, not by whether the water would technically be called an acid.

The two-line summary. *Claim: the ocean's absorption of carbon dioxide has slowed warming but lowered its pH. Concession: "acidification" is a misleading name, because the water is still alkaline — and the misleading name does not make the effect small.*

Note the signposts: "**has not been free**" announces the cost; "**convenient but imprecise**" announces the qualification; "**because the scale is logarithmic**" announces the author's own conclusion.

Question one — explicit detail. *According to the passage, the surface pH of the ocean has fallen* (a) from 8.2 to 7.9 · (b) from about 8.2 to about 8.1 · (c) by about thirty per cent · (d) to a value below neutral.

(b). Written down in one sentence. (c) is Pattern 4, the lifted phrase — "thirty per cent" is in the passage, attached to hydrogen ion **concentration**, not to pH. (d) is Pattern 5, a reversal of the passage's explicit point.

Question two — inference. *It follows from the passage that* (a) the ocean will become acidic if emissions continue · (b) shell-forming organisms are unaffected by a change so small · (c) a small change in pH can represent a large change in hydrogen ion concentration · (d) the ocean should stop absorbing carbon dioxide.

(c). Necessarily true given the logarithmic scale — the passage supplies both halves. (a) is Pattern 1, contradicted outright by "*nothing in the projections suggests*". (b) is Pattern 5, the reversal of the last sentence. (d) is Pattern 3, absent and also incoherent.

Question three — vocabulary in context. *The word "imprecise" as used in the passage means* (a) deliberately misleading · (b) not accurate in its terms · (c) unscientific · (d) recently coined.

(b). The author calls the name *convenient* in the same breath, so he is not alleging deceit — which rules out (a), the option that overstates the charge. Nothing supports (c) or (d). Note how the **adjacent word** decided this, exactly as §3.3 says it will.

THINK LIKE UPSC · WHAT THAT PASSAGE WAS REALLY TESTING

Not knowledge of chemistry. You could answer all three knowing nothing about carbonate chemistry, and your knowledge of F9.3 §3.2 would not have helped with any of them.

What it tested was whether you noticed **three qualifications**: that the service was not free, that the name is imprecise, and that imprecise does not mean unimportant. Each is signalled by an ordinary word — *not free, but imprecise, not by whether*.

The passage rewards attention to small structural words, and punishes attention to nouns. That is the whole format.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSIONS 4 AND 5

1. Name the six wrong-option patterns
2. What is the six-word habit, and which other exam format needs it?
3. Why does prior knowledge of the subject create a specific risk here?
4. Is familiar phrasing evidence for or against an option?

6. Graded Practice — 20 Questions ★★★★★

Four passages, five questions each — the 2023 shape. Target **5 minutes per passage set**, so 20 minutes for the whole bank. Read each passage once, make the two-line summary, then answer.

6.1 Passage I — Contribution and coverage

The distinction between social assistance and social insurance is often blurred in popular discussion, yet it is the distinction on which the architecture of Indian social security rests. Social assistance is financed from general revenues and is given on the basis of need; the beneficiary contributes nothing, and the state's obligation is defined by the terms of the scheme rather than by anything the beneficiary has paid. Social insurance, by contrast, is financed by contributions from employer and employee, and the benefit is claimed as a matter of right earned by those contributions. The Employees' Provident Funds and Miscellaneous Provisions Act, 1952 belongs firmly to the second category. It does not ask whether a member is poor; it asks whether contributions have been paid.

This has a consequence that critics of the Act frequently overlook. Because entitlement follows contribution, the Act can protect only those who are already in recorded employment. A worker outside the organised sector is not excluded by any hostile provision — he is excluded by the absence of an employer to contribute on his behalf. Extending coverage therefore requires either a redefinition of employment or a shift towards the assistance model, and not merely an amendment raising the wage ceiling.

- Q1.** The passage is mainly concerned with (a) establishing that social assistance is a fairer model than social insurance (b) recommending an amendment to raise the wage ceiling under the 1952 Act (c) showing how the contributory basis of the Act explains both what it guarantees and whom it cannot reach (d) demonstrating that popular discussion of social security is generally well informed
- Q2.** According to the passage, social assistance is financed from (a) general revenues (b) contributions from employer and employee (c) a levy on the organised sector (d) the beneficiary's own accumulated savings
- Q3.** It follows from the passage that an amendment raising the wage ceiling would (a) bring most unorganised sector workers within the Act (b) convert the Act into a social assistance measure (c) remove the requirement of an employer's contribution (d) leave the unorganised worker excluded, because his exclusion has a different cause
- Q4.** The word **blurred** as used in the passage means (a) deliberately concealed (b) not clearly distinguished (c) wrongly recorded (d) recently altered
- Q5.** The author's purpose is best described as (a) correcting a confusion and drawing out its consequence (b) condemning the drafting of the 1952 Act (c) comparing Indian social security with that of other countries (d) recommending a particular statutory amendment

6.2 Passage II — What an audit can and cannot deliver

An audit is an independent examination of financial information, undertaken with a view to expressing an opinion on whether the statements give a true and fair view. Each element of that sentence is doing work. The examination is independent, which is why the auditor neither prepares the accounts nor manages the enterprise. The outcome is an opinion, not a certificate: the auditor does not guarantee, he judges. And the standard is a true and fair view rather than absolute accuracy, because accounts embody estimates — of useful life, of recoverability, of provision — on which reasonable people differ.

The reason for this modest phrasing is evidential rather than diplomatic. Audit evidence is largely persuasive rather than conclusive; the auditor tests samples, relies in part on internal controls, and obtains confirmations from third parties who may themselves be mistaken. Collusion within an enterprise may defeat procedures that were properly designed and properly performed. It follows that an audit is designed to give reasonable, not absolute, assurance, and that the failure of an audit to uncover a concealed fraud does not by itself establish that the audit was inadequate. Whether it was inadequate depends on what the auditor did, not on what he failed to find.

Q6. According to the passage, the auditor's report is (a) a certificate that the accounts are arithmetically accurate (b) an expression of opinion (c) a guarantee that no fraud has occurred (d) a representation made by the management of the enterprise

Q7. The passage implies that an audit which failed to detect a well-concealed fraud (a) is for that reason negligent (b) proves that the financial statements were false (c) must be performed again at the auditor's own cost (d) is not, for that reason alone, shown to have been inadequate

Q8. The word **persuasive** as used in the passage means (a) forceful in expression (b) legally binding on the enterprise (c) tending to convince without being conclusive (d) obtained under compulsion of law

Q9. Which one of the following is **not** stated or implied in the passage? (a) The auditor is responsible for preparing the financial statements (b) The auditor tests samples rather than every transaction (c) Accounts embody estimates on which reasonable people may differ (d) Absolute assurance is not the object of an audit

Q10. The author's principal purpose in the passage is to (a) criticise auditors for the caution of their language (b) explain the procedures by which an audit is conducted (c) argue that the standard of audit should be raised to absolute accuracy (d) explain why the auditor's conclusion is deliberately expressed in qualified terms

6.3 Passage III — A service and its price

The ocean has absorbed roughly a quarter of the carbon dioxide released by human activity since industrialisation, and has thereby slowed atmospheric warming appreciably. The service has not been free. Dissolved carbon dioxide forms carbonic acid, which dissociates and releases hydrogen ions, and the surface pH of the ocean has fallen from about 8.2 to about 8.1 in that period. The process is universally called ocean acidification.

The name is convenient but imprecise. Seawater at pH 8.1 is alkaline, and no projection suggests it will become acidic in the ordinary sense of that word. What has occurred is a measurable shift towards the acidic end of the scale. Because the scale is logarithmic, however, that apparently trivial movement represents an increase of some thirty per cent in the concentration of hydrogen ions — and it is that concentration, not the label attached to the water, which governs the ability of organisms to build shells of calcium carbonate. The imprecision of the term has had an unfortunate rhetorical consequence: those who wish to minimise the problem point out, correctly, that the ocean is not becoming an acid, and treat the correction as though it disposed of the argument.

Q11. According to the passage, the surface pH of the ocean has fallen (a) from about 8.2 to about 8.1 (b) from about 8.2 to below 7.0 (c) by about thirty per cent (d) to a value at which seawater is no longer alkaline

Q12. On the passage's own account, the term *ocean acidification* is imprecise because (a) the ocean absorbs only a quarter of the carbon dioxide released (b) the pH scale is logarithmic rather than linear (c) seawater remains alkaline throughout the change described (d) hydrogen ion concentration cannot be measured directly

Q13. The word **sink**, if used in this passage to describe the ocean, would most nearly mean (a) a process by which a substance is destroyed (b) a reservoir that takes up more of a substance than it releases (c) a channel through which a substance passes unchanged (d) a measure of the depth at which a substance settles

Q14. It can be inferred from the passage that the author regards the objection that the ocean is not becoming an acid as (a) factually mistaken and rhetorically dishonest (b) factually mistaken but rhetorically effective (c) factually correct and sufficient to settle the question (d) factually correct but not an answer to the argument

Q15. The author's tone in the passage is best described as (a) indignant (b) explanatory and careful about terminology (c) indifferent to the consequences described (d) dismissive of the scientific evidence

6.4 Passage IV — Work without an employer

Social insurance was built on an assumption so ordinary that it was rarely stated: that a worker has an employer, and that the employer can be required to contribute. The platform economy does not deny that assumption so much as dissolve it. A person who drives for an aggregator or delivers for a marketplace works, often for long hours, and often for a single entity that determines his rates and rates his performance. But the legal relationship is framed as one between independent parties, and the obligation to contribute that the older statutes attached to employment has no natural place to attach.

The Code on Social Security, 2020 responds not by asserting that platform workers are employees but by creating a separate contributory base. It defines the gig worker and the platform worker as categories in their own right, and requires the aggregator to contribute at a rate fixed as a percentage of its annual turnover — between one and two per cent — subject to a ceiling expressed as a proportion of what it pays the workers concerned. The design is instructive. It concedes that the employment relationship is attenuated, and then locates the contribution in the only place that remains reliably identifiable: the revenue of the platform itself. Whether that yields adequate benefits is a separate question from whether it yields any, and it is the second question the Code was drafted to answer.

Q16. The passage is mainly about (a) the inadequacy of the benefits available to platform workers (b) the legal test by which an employment relationship is identified (c) how social security law has responded to work that lacks an identifiable employer (d) the rates of contribution payable under the Code on Social Security, 2020

Q17. According to the passage, the aggregator's contribution is fixed as (a) a deduction from the worker's earnings at source (b) a percentage of the aggregator's annual turnover, subject to a ceiling related to what it pays its workers (c) a flat annual amount for each registered worker (d) a levy on each transaction concluded on the platform

Q18. The passage implies that the central difficulty the platform economy creates for social insurance is that (a) it separates the fact of work from the existence of an entity obliged to contribute (b) platform workers earn too little for contributions to be meaningful (c) aggregators are generally unwilling to comply with statutory obligations (d) platform work is usually temporary and therefore outside any statute

Q19. The word **attenuated** as used in the passage means (a) formally abolished (b) legally disputed (c) precisely defined (d) weakened without being eliminated

Q20. The last sentence of the passage suggests that the author regards the Code's approach as (a) a complete solution to the problem of platform work (b) an evasion of the question of employment status (c) a limited but genuine advance, whose adequacy remains open (d) irrelevant to the workers it purports to cover

7. Answers and Explanations

7.1 Passage I

Q	Ans	Explanation
1	c	Claim plus qualification, which §3.4 says is nearly always the shape of the right option. (a) and (d) are contradicted — the author never ranks the two models, and says popular discussion blurs the distinction. (b) is the recommendation the passage explicitly rejects in its last clause
2	a	Explicit: <i>"financed from general revenues"</i> . (b) is the definition of social insurance , offered as Pattern 4 — the passage's own words attached to the wrong category
3	d	The last sentence says extending coverage needs redefinition or a shift of model, <i>"and not merely an amendment raising the wage ceiling"</i> , and the reason is given: the unorganised worker lacks a contributing employer. (a) reverses the passage. (b) and (c) add facts the passage does not supply
4	b	Vocabulary in context. <i>Blurred</i> here describes a distinction not clearly drawn; (a) imputes deliberate concealment, which the sentence does not — the author blames imprecision, not bad faith. §3.3's rule: the sentence decides
5	a	The structure is a correction (<i>"often blurred"</i>) followed by a consequence (<i>"This has a consequence that critics frequently overlook"</i>). (b) overstates — the author defends the Act's logic. (d) is the option the last sentence forecloses

7.2 Passage II

Q	Ans	Explanation
6	b	Explicit: <i>"The outcome is an opinion, not a certificate."</i> (a) and (c) are the two guarantees the passage denies; (d) reverses the independence point in the first paragraph
7	d	The passage states it almost in terms: failure to uncover a concealed fraud <i>"does not by itself establish that the audit was inadequate"</i> , because adequacy depends on what was done. (a) is the reversal; (b) and (c) are Pattern 3, outside the passage entirely
8	c	The word is defined by its own contrast in the sentence — <i>"persuasive rather than conclusive"</i> . This is the clearest possible case of §3.3: the adjacent word settles it
9	a	The "not" question. The passage says the opposite: <i>"the auditor neither prepares the accounts nor manages the enterprise."</i> (b), (c) and (d) are each stated. Note that reading only the first four words of the stem loses this mark — Blueprint §8's habit
10	d	The second paragraph opens by announcing exactly this: <i>"The reason for this modest phrasing is evidential rather than diplomatic."</i> (a) inverts the author's sympathy; (b) is too narrow, procedures being mentioned only as evidence; (c) is contradicted

7.3 Passage III

Q	Ans	Explanation
11	a	Explicit. (c) is Pattern 4 — thirty per cent belongs to hydrogen ion concentration , not to pH, and the two are related logarithmically. (b) and (d) contradict " <i>Seawater at pH 8.1 is alkaline</i> "
12	c	The passage's own reason: the water is alkaline and is not projected to become acidic. (b) is a true statement from the passage, but it is the reason the change is significant , not the reason the name is imprecise — Pattern 6, the right answer to a different question
13	b	Vocabulary in context, tested on a word the passage does not use, which forces you to reason from the described function: the ocean takes up and retains carbon dioxide. (a) is wrong because the carbon is not destroyed; the passage traces exactly what becomes of it
14	d	The last sentence: those who minimise the problem " <i>point out, correctly, that the ocean is not becoming an acid, and treat the correction as though it disposed of the argument.</i> " Correct, but not an answer. (a) and (b) both call it mistaken; the author expressly concedes it is right. (c) is what the author is arguing against
15	b	The passage explains, distinguishes and qualifies; it never raises its voice. §3.5's rule that the milder tone option wins in this register. (a) is the tempting overreach, given the final sentence's evident impatience

7.4 Passage IV

Q	Ans	Explanation
16	c	Claim plus response, covering both paragraphs. (d) is Pattern 1's cousin, too narrow — the contribution rate is one detail. (a) is the question the last sentence explicitly sets aside. (b) is never discussed
17	b	Explicit, and the detail matters: a percentage of turnover , capped by reference to what is paid to workers. (a) reverses who pays; (c) and (d) are plausible mechanisms the passage does not mention — Pattern 3
18	a	The first paragraph's whole point: the person works, often for a single controlling entity, but the obligation <i>"has no natural place to attach."</i> (b), (c) and (d) may be true in the world and are the trap of §4.3 — none is in the passage
19	d	<i>Attenuated</i> means thinned or weakened. The passage confirms the sense by contrast: the relationship is attenuated, so the Code responds <i>"not by asserting that platform workers are employees"</i> — weakened, not abolished, which is why (a) fails
20	c	<i>"Whether that yields adequate benefits is a separate question from whether it yields any, and it is the second question the Code was drafted to answer."</i> That is a defence of the Code's modest ambition, so (a) overstates and (b) and (d) misread the author's sympathy

THINK LIKE UPSC · THE FOUR THINGS THIS BANK WAS DRILLING

1. **The qualification carries the marks.** Q3, Q7, Q14 and Q20 all turn on the sentence after a *but*, a *however* or a *not merely*. Four of twenty questions, and in each case the claim itself was uncontroversial. **Mark the qualification as you read**
2. **The "not" stem.** Q9. About **20% of the 2023 paper** used this format (Blueprint §6). Here the wrong-looking option is the one that is actually **stated**, and the answer is the one that is not — which inverts every instinct you have built. Re-read the stem
3. **Prior knowledge as a liability.** Q12 and Q18 both offer true statements that are not in the passage. If you have studied Module 3 and F9.3 you were more exposed to these, not less. Point at the sentence
4. **The distinction between correct and sufficient.** Q14 and Q20. UPSC likes options that are true but do not answer the question asked, and the discipline of §4's Pattern 6 — re-read the stem after choosing — is what catches them

8. One-Minute Revision

ONE-MINUTE REVISION · CHAPTER F8.3

WEIGHT 5 of 20 English questions in 2023, **all on ONE passage** · **budget 5 minutes for the set**

THE ORDER scan stems for **type only, 20 sec** » read **once**, 90–110 sec » answer ~35 sec each
» **main idea LAST**

READ FOR FOUR THINGS the **claim** · the **qualification** after *but / however / yet* · the **evidence** · the **consequence**

THE TWO-LINE SUMMARY *what is the author claiming? what is he conceding?* — made **before** you look at any option. It answers main idea, purpose and tone by itself

MARK THE SENTENCE AFTER "HOWEVER" — it carries the inference question more often than any other

FIVE QUESTION TYPES explicit detail (findable) · inference (**must** follow) · vocabulary in context (**this** sentence, not the dictionary) · main idea (claim + qualification) · tone (read the verbs)

INFERENCE TEST *could the passage be true and this option still be false?* If yes, reject

MAIN IDEA FAILS BY too narrow · too broad · not in the passage

TONE almost never *sarcastic, indignant, contemptuous, indifferent* · almost always **analytical, explanatory, corrective, measured** · when two survive, take the **milder**

SIX WRONG-OPTION PATTERNS **1** overreach (*all, never, only, must*) · **2** half-truth (right start, wrong finish) · **3** outside truth (true but not in the passage) · **4** lifted phrase (real words, wrong fact) · **5** reversal (cause and effect swapped) · **6** right answer to the wrong question

READ THE LAST SIX WORDS OF EVERY OPTION — the half-truth is the hardest wrong answer to catch

POINT AT THE SENTENCE. If your finger does not land, the option is out however true it is

FAMILIAR PHRASING IS WEAK EVIDENCE FOR AN OPTION. THE CORRECT OPTION IS USUALLY A PARAPHRASE

9. Five-Minute Wall Sheet

FIVE-MINUTE WALL SHEET · CHAPTER F8.3

FIVE QUESTIONS, ONE PASSAGE — SO READING IT CAREFULLY IS THE CHEAPEST 12.5 MARKS IN THE ENGLISH BLOCK

STEMS FOR TYPE (20 SEC) » PASSAGE ONCE » ANSWER » MAIN IDEA LAST

CLAIM · QUALIFICATION · EVIDENCE · CONSEQUENCE — the only four things to look for

TWO LINES BEFORE ANY OPTION: WHAT IS CLAIMED? WHAT IS CONCEDED?

TICK THE SENTENCE AFTER *HOWEVER* — IT IS THE INFERENCE QUESTION

INFERENCE = MUST FOLLOW, NOT LIKELY. *ALL · NEVER · ONLY · MUST* ARE USUALLY OVERREACH

VOCABULARY: THE ADJACENT WORD DECIDES, NOT THE DICTIONARY

MILD TONE WINS. POLICY PROSE DOES NOT SHOUT

POINT AT THE SENTENCE OR DROP THE OPTION

READ THE LAST SIX WORDS — AND RE-READ THE STEM FOR THE WORD *NOT*

TRUE IS NOT THE SAME AS RESPONSIVE

ONE LINE FOR THE INTERVIEW A comprehension passage tests whether you can separate what a text asserts from what you already believe — which is the same discipline an adjudicating officer needs when the record before him and his own impression of the employer point in different directions.

ACTION · NEXT

F8.4 — Grammar Essentials and Error Spotting. It is the supporting format rather than a heavily weighted one, which is exactly why it is written to be finished quickly: the patterns are finite, and they also protect the marks in F8.1 and F8.2.

Tonight's drill, per F8.0's week 3 Monday cell: **\$6 Q1–10, timed at ten minutes for the two passage sets.**